BIRTH OF THE UN

The idealism of the founding fathers of the League of Nations to prevent large-scale war was shattered as the world was caught up again in another massive war—the Second World War. The League failed to prevent the War and its fate became sealed with the outbreak of the War. However, there was a renewed effort on the part of the international community to establish an international organization to save the future generations from the scourge of war. The United States, under President Franklin Roosevelt was in favour of a global peacekeeping agency and Roosevelt himself coined the name “United Nations”. In the course of the War, the urge for such an international organization led to the signing of the historic Atlantic Charter on 14 August 1941.

The Inter-Allied Declaration of 12 June 1941 upheld a promise “to work together, with other free people, both in war and in peace”. Thereafter, on 14 August 1941 Franklin D Roosevelt, President of the United States and Winston Churchill, Prime Minister of the United Kingdom, signed the Atlantic Charter during their meeting on the ship *HMS Prince of Wales*. This marked the historic beginning of the United Nations.

The next step towards the formation of the United Nations was the Declaration by United Nations on 1 January 1942. Twenty-six allied nations signed the “Declaration by United Nations” in Washington DC. This document contained the first official use of the term ‘United Nations’. This initiative was further given a boost in the Moscow Declaration on 30 October 1943, which envisioned “a general international organization based on the principle of sovereign equality of all peace loving states… large and small, for the maintenance of international peace and security”.[1] The endeavour picked up momentum and, on 1 December 1943, the Tehran Declaration was adopted, which drew up a plan for an international organization for peacekeeping. The principles of these two declarations were reaffirmed in the Dumbarton Oaks Conference held between 21 September and 7 October 1944, where the blueprint of the international body was prepared. Major decisions